many issues were discussed, including the supply of this non-lethal hardware, which he had assured would materialize soon. I sought a meeting and went and met the COAS, explaining the situation and making an impassioned plea for something, anything to be given. I told him it would be a great blow to our reputation if something he had promised were not to materialize before he retired later that month. Besides, I added, my tenure was ending in June 2010, and I would like to leave on a high. I don't know what strings he pulled, but the file suddenly started moving. Gen VK Singh who took over from him as the COAS, and who had also visited Myanmar in his capacity of Army Commander, Eastern Command, followed up on it. Out of the entire MA projection, two dozers were finally made available, which were ceremonially handed over at the Tamu–Moreh border in June 2010, just before my return. That was the India story—tall on promises, short on delivery.

When I had deployed to Myanmar in 2007, the selection board for my batch from Colonel to Brigadier had already been held, the results of which were declared in November of that year. My batchmates had started picking up their Brigadier rank from January 2008 and had already finished commanding their Brigades. I was thus about two and a half years behind and had to wait to return to India to pick up my rank, as promotions while abroad were not permitted. Since I was in Delhi to follow up on the dozer case, I went to meet the Colonel of the Regiment, Lt Gen Bikram Singh, who was then the DGSD, but slated to go to Eastern Command once Gen VK Singh became the Chief. I told him that I was due for promotion to the rank of Brigadier and sought his advice on where to go for my Brigade command. Though he did not immediately indicate anything, he said he would look into it and I knew that he would do what was best.

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